A Ballad of Stardust

They Loved One Another Across Countless Ages

Once upon a time, the melodic voice of Mother Earth first awakened the blossoms of life. Before the hundredth ocean had become even a puddle, and before the hundredth mountain of Sumeru had risen beyond a humble hill, two magnificent peaks towered in breathtaking majesty, facing each other from the East and the West, high above the reach of even the mythical Garuda.
Every morning, the Western Mountain gazed in wonder at the golden sun rising behind the Eastern Mountain. Day after day, captivated by that enchanting, breathtaking sight, it gradually fell in love with the Eastern Mountain. The Eastern Mountain, meanwhile, spent every evening enthralled by Lady Sun dipping behind the Western Mountain, her soul deeply entwined with his.

Yet a vast ocean lay between them, keeping the two mountains forever apart. They were destined only to gaze at one another from afar for thousands upon thousands of years. And so they made a promise: they would love each other until the day the sun cast its final light upon the Earth and the universe was swallowed by utter darkness.

As millions of years rolled by, the vast ocean dried into a wide river. Battered by countless meteor showers, driven by the eastern winds, and eroded by the rushing waters, the two giant mountains slowly dwindled until they were but small stones, no larger than the palm of a hand. In their endless shrinking, until they could barely discern each other's silhouette, there existed no beings in this world more blissful, yet more sorrowful, than they. Even as they crumbled, their resolve to love remained unshaken, and they agreed to meet one day, sooner or later, upon the eastern bank of the wide river.

The little stone that had once been the Western Mountain, determined to reach the river's eastern bank, spoke to every living creature that passed by:

> *"Listen, all of you! When meteor showers rained endlessly from the heavens, you sheltered beneath me. When calamities threatened to drown the world, you climbed to my summit for refuge. When the Earth turned into a frozen sphere, you made homes for yourselves in every hollow and crevice of mine. It is beyond question that my very existence sustained yours and helped you survive to this day.*

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Now, the time has come for you to repay your debt to the great Western Mountain. Across the river stands the Eastern Mountain—the one and only purpose, the very meaning of my life. Carry me there, without allowing even a single grain of me to crumble away. Do this, and I shall consider our debt settled."

Every living creature heard the little stone, but not one paid it any heed. Instead, they mocked the arrogant little stone, whose immense ego seemed far too large for its tiny body, as it loudly proclaimed that it had once been a mountain reaching to the heavens.
The mighty Western Mountain, which had once towered above all things, had only now come to understand that its reputation, its glory, its great deeds, and even the story of its life had shrunk with the passing of time, becoming as insignificant as its present form. With nowhere to turn, it could do little more than sit somewhere in the depths of a lush green forest, lamenting its fate and cursing all living things.

The story of the two mountains of the West and East—who had been the meaning of each other's existence and the very embodiment of beauty in one another's eyes, and who had endured upon this green Earth for countless ages—is surely one that would move anyone who saw it or heard it.
And yet every living being in this world is bound by a different measure of time. Each has only its own allotted span in which to discover the meaning and essence of life. Some are granted billions of years, as the Western and Eastern Mountains were, to find the purpose of their existence. Others are given no more than a fleeting moment—time that passes in the blink of an eye, like a fly's life.

Deep in that forest lived a woodpecker, cast out by his flock because of his unusually small stature. Though the little bird knew how tiny he was, he believed with all his heart that he would one day discover his purpose in this vast world. With that dream in its heart, it wandered through the forest, searching for the reason it had been born.

One day, as it flew along as usual, barely managing to beat its tiny wings and with little idea of where it was headed, the woodpecker came upon a small stone that believed it had once been a colossal mountain. Having heard the other creatures shun the stone and laugh at it, the curious bird approached and asked:

"Little stone, dear little stone, why are you sitting here like this?"

The little stone, drowning in a sea of sorrow, replied:

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"*Yes, I am now just a small stone. None believe that I was once a mighty mountain that sustained all life. Yet, my love for the Eastern Mountain remains as monumental as my ancient peaks. Half of my heart still lingers on the other side of the river. What greater despair is there than being unable to even draw near to her*?"

And so it told the little bird the story of its existence.

Having listened to its tale, the little woodpecker said:
"*Dear Western Mountain, dear Western Mountain, I tried to fathom your devotion to the Eastern Mountain, but it is a grandeur far beyond my small mind. Since fate has turned this way, do not grieve. Steady your heart. Love, it seems, is vaster than the mightiest mountain and brighter than the golden sun. If it lives in your soul, you must give everything to write this chronicle of love. To offer what little help a small winged creature can, I shall hold you in my beak and carry you to the far side of the wide river.*"

The little woodpecker tried again and again, biting at the stone from every side in an effort to lift it, but to no avail. Seeing this tiny bird in the vast forest, the only creature who had listened to its words and was now straining with all its might to help, the little Western Stone finally let go of its pride and spoke:

"Once, I was a mountain so tall that I seemed to touch the heavens. When I reigned over the highest peaks of the world, every living creature looked up to me in awe, and I imagined that all of them sought shelter at my feet. I never once imagined—let alone dreamed—that I could become so small and powerless.

But look at me now. Power and strength, I have learned, are only fleeting things, carried away by the passage of time. All that remains in the folds of my memory are a few fading recollections. And every one of them is tied to that same beautiful Eastern Mountain.

If becoming small enough to fit in your beak is the only way I might see my beloved once more, then I would do so without hesitation."

Moved by the stone's words, the little woodpecker set about helping to write this beautiful and courageous love story. It pecked and pecked until its beak broke, laboring for a long, long time until the stone split into several pieces. At last, it managed to grasp the tiniest fragment in its beak and rose into the sky.

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Poor little woodpecker struggled to endure the pain of its broken beak as it flew. But when it reached the very middle of the great river, the pain became too much to bear, and the tiny fragment of the Western Stone slipped from its beak and fell.

From that moment on, the little fragment never saw the woodpecker again.

Did the little woodpecker find the purpose of its life? Or had the purpose of its life been fulfilled only moments before?

"Love is the hardest story to write, yet the sweetest novel to read."

What fault was there in the little woodpecker, who had willingly chosen to help write this love story? Perhaps the fragment of the Western Stone was destined to learn from that bird—who had sacrificed its beak for their love—that love is indeed a most difficult story to write.

From then on, the tiny fragment of the Western Stone had no choice but to surrender to the current of the great river. As it drifted along, it imagined again and again, billions upon billions of times, the beautiful sight of the Eastern Mountain at sunrise.

Across the river, a gentle breeze could be heard from afar. It had spent its entire existence roaming the world, carrying away the sorrows, regrets, and tears of others. Now it caught a whisper so moving that it seemed to rise from somewhere beyond the horizon.

The whisper, which could be heard from somewhere in the far reaches of the Earth, told of an existence both immeasurably long and impossibly beautiful, and of the beloved whom its speaker had resolved to love for all eternity. It said:

"Every evening, as the sun went down, how beautiful that great Western Mountain looked, standing there, always facing me. How peaceful it made me feel to watch the rain clouds dance around its mist-veiled slopes. I never grew tired of counting, year after year, every single tree that grew upon it. And when dark clouds covered the Earth for millions of years, how deeply I grieved because I could no longer see it.

I could replay every memory connected to my beloved over and over in my mind, and never grow tired of a single one."

"I will love my beloved until I have turned to a speck of dust and can wait no longer. I will love my beloved until the entire Earth becomes a ball of fire, and nothing upon it

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can continue to exist. I will love my beloved until the last sun in another solar system, far beyond anything we could ever see, has burned out. I will love only my beloved until the day the whole universe is shrouded in absolute darkness."

The tender breeze listened to these stories and transformed them into a beautiful melody, carrying it to every corner of the Earth. Even the Western Mountain, lying at the bottom of the river, heard it.

It is said that the entire world mourned for the two mountains, and rain poured down for three days and three nights. The torrential downpour caused a flood, and the flood carried the tiny Eastern Stone all the way to the riverbank.

If anything in this world is truly merciless, it is time—and, second only to time, fate. Not even the beautiful Lady Sun, who illuminates the world, nor the magnificent mountains of the West and East, towering above all things, can defy them. It is heartbreaking to know that they, too, will slowly fade and one day disappear.

As the little Eastern Stone waited on the riverbank, another half-century passed. Not a single day went by without it telling the story of its entire existence. It had no idea when it would meet its beloved, or where its beloved might be. All it had was hope. And that hope alone was enough.

Time continued to pass, and even the rocks and cliffs slowly wore away. One day, a boulder unexpectedly broke loose from the rocky ravine that had sheltered the little stone in its shadow. It tumbled down the slope and struck the tiny Eastern Stone head-on. The stone shattered into several pieces, and its smallest fragment leapt into the great river.

Theirs was a love story almost impossible to write. Neither knew that, trapped among the rocks in the same river, they were enduring precisely the same journey—battered by the river's waves and worn away, little by little. Each continued to dream of the other in solitude, doing everything it could to protect its faith and devotion.

Millions upon millions of years flowed by. The great river dried up completely dozens of times, only to swell again to the size of an ocean just as often. At last, the life of Mother Sun drew to its end, and the moment came for her to cast her final light upon the Earth.

Upon this immense planet, where all forms of existence had once flourished, evolved, and transformed, every speck of dust and every particle of cosmic matter rose and swirled in a

great, chaotic dance. And there, amid that boundless turmoil, the two specks of dust who had searched for and loved each other across countless ages finally found one another.

Touching for the very first time, they danced in circles, laughing and coughing, completing this extraordinary chronicle of love. Proving that where love exists, time, existence, and suffering hold no terror, the final ray of sunlight surrendered to absolute darkness—and perhaps to something deeper still. Yet, within this dark void, we know that these two glow with incomparable beauty, orbiting each other, loving just as they did billions of years ago.

"Have you been waiting for me for terribly long? I'm sorry."
"Not at all. It was far quicker than I had imagined."
"How much time do we have before we are erased completely and fade into nothingness?"
"Why should that matter? For the first time in all these years, I have finally felt what it means to be alive. That is what matters most to me."

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